Lesson 12 material: Active Reading: Asking Questions and Annotating

1.4: Using Questions to Be an Active Reader

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Original page, with audio and online exercises:
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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Reading as an active process

Reading is not a passive process. As good readers, we are constantly connecting our own knowledge to the text and using different strategies to understand. In 1.3: Identifying Reading Strategies and Prereading a Text we have already looked at two strategies: prereading and using a KWL+ chart to connect the text to what you already know about the topic and what you want to learn. Here are some other strategies that you might use to read actively. Which strategies do you usually use? Are there others that you want to try?

- Skipping confusing parts and returning to them after you finish
- Taking notes about the main points of each section
- Reading some parts quickly and some parts slowly
- Reading again
- Telling someone else what you understand

Telling someone about the reading

Let's try another active reading strategy: telling someone else about what you understand. Reading quickly with a timer makes you search for the overall meaning without stopping to look up words or get caught in the small details. Like signs at a protest (see Figure 1.4.1), you can only focus on the most important ideas.

(Picture: a child in a stroller holds a sign at a protest reading "Education Not Deportation")

Figure: "Los Angeles March for Immigrant Rights" by Molly Adams is licensed under CC-BY 2.0.

Try this!

Here is a report from UNICEF (United Nations Childrens' Fund). Follow these steps:

1. Set a timer for 2 minutes.
2. Read as much as you can in 2 minutes.
3. In your own words, tell a classmate what you understand from the reading.
4. Set the timer for 2 minutes and read again from the top.
5. Again, tell your classmate what you understand from the reading.
6. Read the entire report again without a timer and tell your partner again what you learned.
7. Discuss whether this helped you to understand the report.

Reading an International Report: A Child is a Child: Protecting Children on the Move from Violence, Abuse and Exploitation

Millions of children are on the move across international borders – fleeing violence and conflict, disaster or poverty, in pursuit of a better life. Hundreds of thousands move on their own. When they encounter few opportunities to move legally, children resort to dangerous routes and engage smugglers to help them cross borders. Serious gaps in the laws, policies and services meant to protect children on the move further leave them bereft of protection and care. Deprived, unprotected, and often alone, children on the move can become easy prey for traffickers and others who abuse and exploit them.

Many children move alone and face particularly grave risks. In parts of the world, the number of children moving on their own has skyrocketed. On the dangerous Central Mediterranean Sea passage from North Africa to Europe, 92 per cent of children who arrived in Italy in 2016 and the first two months of 2017 were unaccompanied, up from 75 per cent in 2015. At least 300,000 unaccompanied and separated children moving across borders were registered in 80 countries in 2015–2016 – a near fivefold increase from 66,000 in 2010–2011. The total number of unaccompanied and separated children on the move worldwide is likely much higher.

Specific reasons motivate children to undertake journeys alone. Many seek to reunite with family members already abroad. Others pursue their families' aspirations for this generation to have a better life. Perceptions of the potential benefits of children moving, especially to certain destinations, filter through social networks. Other factors include family breakdown, domestic violence, child marriage and forced conscription.

Without safe and legal pathways, children's journeys are rife with risk and exploitation. Whatever their motivation, children often find few opportunities to move legally. Family reunification, humanitarian visas, refugee resettlement spots, and work or study visas are out of reach for most. But barriers to legal migration do not stop people from moving, they only push them underground.

Wherever families and children desperate to move encounter barriers, smuggling in human beings thrives. Smugglers range from people helping others in need for a fee to organized criminal networks that deliver children into hazardous and exploitative situations.

Once children and families place their fates in the hands of smugglers, the transaction can readily take a turn towards abuse or exploitation – especially when children and families incur debts to pay smugglers' fees. Europol estimates that 20 per cent of suspected smugglers on their radar have ties to human trafficking – they help children cross borders, only to sell them into exploitation, sometimes akin to contemporary forms of slavery.

Questioning for active reading

One of the best ways to read actively is to ask questions before, during, and after we read. These questions help us to set goals for reading, understand what we are reading, and check our understanding afterwards. When we ask questions, it is as though we are having a conversation with the writer: What do you mean here? Where did this happen? Who is involved? Why is this important? How does this relate to the refugee crisis? How did you arrive at that conclusion? When we ask questions, we read with purpose and more depth. As we read and some questions are answered, new questions will arise.

Look at Table 1.4.1. Which of these questions do you currently ask before, during, and after you read a text? Which ones do you not use that you would like to try?

Table 1.4.1 Questions that can be asked before reading, during reading, and after reading

Before Reading	During Reading	After Reading										
Why am I reading this text? What am I expected to do with or get out of this text? Do I need to answer questions? Find the main idea? Use this text in an essay?	What type of text is it? Is it an article, research paper, a blog, a tweet, a TED talk, etc?	Who is the author? What are their credentials (a person's background and qualifications)? What is the name of the publication? When was the text written?	What is the title? Are there any headings/subheadings or graphic aids (e.g., images, graphs, tables, charts) that give me clues about the topic/key points?	What do I know about the topic and how do I feel about it?	What do I think the text will teach me?	Do I have any biases about the topic because of my feelings towards it? (biases are strong opinions that make it hard to be objective)	What key terms does the author define in the text? Are there any bold-faced, highlighted, italicized words or terms that are repeated throughout the text?	What seems to be the author's purpose or reason for writing this text? Is it to inform, persuade, or entertain? There can be more than one purpose.	Who is the author's audience? For whom did the writer compose this text, and how are they trying to appeal to their audience? (e.g., Is the text written for a history student, a psychology professor, a person's socio-economic status, political affiliation, religious beliefs, or sexual orientation?) There can be more than one audience.	What seems to be the key point(s), or what question(s) is the author trying to answer in the text? What is the thesis, message, or main idea of the text? Ask yourself: what is it mainly about? Can I find clues in the introduction and conclusion? You might scan the first paragraph or introduction and last paragraph or conclusion.	What evidence is provided to support the author's key points? Are they referring to other texts? Statistics? Examples?	Othe Wh-quest word (who what wher wher why, how)

Asking questions as you read

Now let's take a look at an article and ask questions before, during, and after reading it:

Try this!

As you read, "Changes in U.S. Immigration Patterns and Attitudes," ask questions before, during, and after reading the text. Use the chart to help you! Create at least three WH-questions while you read. WH-questions can be fact-based ("How many undocumented immigrants live in the U.S.?") or open-ended "Why do you think that the number of undocumented immigrants has declined since 2007?").

Reading from a textbook: Changes in U.S. Immigration Patterns and Attitudes

Worldwide patterns of migration have changed, though the United States remains the most popular destination. In 2018, there were over 44.8 million immigrants living in the United States (The Pew Research Center 2018). This is more than four times the 9.7 million immigrants in the United States in 1960. In 2015, there were 12.1 million immigrants to the United States from South or East Asia, 11.6 million from Mexico, and 5.6 million from Canada or Europe. Moreover, the source countries of immigrants has changed. In 1960 the vast majority of immigrants came from Europe and Canada, but there was a large shift in during the 1970s and immigration from other parts of the world increased sharply while European and Canadian immigration declined.

While there are more foreign-born people residing in the United States legally (73% of immigrants in 2018), about 10.5 million are undocumented immigrants. This is a sharp decline from a peak of 12.2 million in 2007.

Most U.S. citizens agree that our national immigration policies are in need of change—almost three-quarters of those in a recent national survey believed undocumented immigrants should have a path to citizenship provided they meet other requirements, such as speaking English.

Works Cited

Lumen Learning, *Introduction to Sociology,* 2020.

UNICEF, "A Child is a Child: Protecting Children on the Move from Violence, Abuse and Exploitation Executive Summary." 17 May 2017.

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"A Child is a Child: Protecting Children on the Move from Violence, Abuse and Exploitation" is adapted from UNICEF. License: CC BY NC.

Chart of questions for before, during, and after reading adapted from Lumen Learning, *English Composition 1,* "Questioning." License: CC BY.

"Changes in US Immigration Patterns and Attitudes" adapted from Lumen Learning, *Introduction to Sociology* 20.5: Immigration in the United States. License: CC BY.

1.5: Annotating a Text

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Annotation

"Annotation" means writing notes while you read, usually directly on the text you are reading. While it is common for students to highlight important information in a text, highlighting is considered a passive activity. We want to take notes as we read. Annotating is an important active reading strategy because we engage with a text as the reader. It is as though we are having a conversation with the writer. We might ask them questions, make predictions and connections, or show our agreement or disagreement. We also read a text more closely and retain it better since taking notes slows down our reading process. When it is time to write about a text or take a test, for instance, we will not need to re-read everything, and we can use our annotations instead. Each reader brings their own ideas and background "baggage" to the text, so your annotations will be different from your classmates. Reading is thinking, and like a mirror or a window as in Figure 1.5.1, annotating makes our thinking visible!

(Picture: a youth with a serious expression looks through a car window.)

Figure: "Rearview mirror" by ericklawrence is marked with CC BY 2.0.

Studying an example annotation

Look at the example annotation below. What observations can you make? Discuss with a partner:

Notice this!

First, read the editorial. Think about what parts are important, how the parts connect to each other, and what questions you have.

Editorial from an online magazine: "A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is a Win for All"

Guest Column by Tram Nguyen, *Virginia Mercury*, March 27, 2020

Every person in Virginia deserves to live in their community free from fear.

The exclusion of undocumented Virginians from being able to drive has been a crippling barrier to that principle. But the state legislature has now passed a bill that will allow driving for many immigrant residents through driver privilege cards this session. At New Virginia Majority we have organized and advocated for this basic right, and now previously undocumented families and communities will legally be able to drive in the state of Virginia.

Having the right to drive can be a matter of life and death under everyday circumstances: a sick child that needs immediate medical attention, or a woman getting ready to bring a new life into the world. Most of us take this access for granted. This is a crucial advancement – for those that have waited patiently just to be able to drive themselves to work, take their children to doctor's appointments, or attend local events, this a chance to become fully active members of their community.

Ovidia Castillo Rosa, a member of New Virginia Majority's Loudoun County chapter described it best: "Not having a driver's license is like not having feet. Being able to drive would be like having wings. When I have a driver's license, there are so many things that I'll have the freedom to do, including starting my own business."

Cecilia Cruz, a member of the New Virginia Majority, has been involved in the fight for the right to drive, and has called her representatives, and encouraged her friends and neighbors to march in support. "The streets will be more safe and more money will stay in the state," she said. "Families will be able to leave their children and go to work in safety, without fear."

Providing this credential will give thousands of Virginians the ability to legally drive and is a huge victory. But we recognize driver privilege cards are not the same as driver's licenses, and there is much more to be done. Our communities, in an era of open and growing institutional racism and xenophobia, understand that having a driver's privilege card has the potential to make them vulnerable, as it will make them immediately identifiable as an undocumented person and creates a segment of immigrant drivers.

Our organizers, advocates, and chapter members will continue to fight for a society that treats people equally and with dignity no matter what their status, language, zip code, gender, race, or ethnicity is, and we will work to strengthen privacy protections for all Virginians, regardless of immigration status.

When the presidential election comes to a close in the fall, we pledge to stand by immigrant communities and keep them informed of both the opportunities and threats presented by this law, regardless of who holds the office.

We believe in a Virginia that is welcoming and provides an opportunity for all its residents to succeed and live happy and healthy lives. The outcome of this legislative session was a step in the right direction and toward a more inclusive Virginia. But until all of our communities are granted the full protections and access to driver's licenses, the fight continues.

Tram Nguyen is co-executive director of New Virginia Majority, which works to builds power in working-class communities of color, in immigrant communities, among LGBTQ people, women, youth, and progressives across the commonwealth.

"A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is a Win for All" was originally published in the Virginia Mercury and is licensed under CC BY NC ND.

Now look at Figure 1.5.2, an annotation of the same text. What do you notice? What else would you add? Discuss with a partner.

(Picture: refer to accessible version of the content)

Figure: "Example annotation" by Gabriel Winer is licensed under CC-BY-NC. Text used verbatim from "A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is a Win for All," originally published in the Virginia Mercury and licensed under CC BY NC ND.

Figure 1.5.1 shows the text of "A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is a Win for all" by Tram Nguyen with some passages highlighted, with notes that summarize key information, ask questions, and respond to wording choices the writer made.

See 1.5.1 for an accessible version of the above model annotation.

Active readers use annotation as a way to

- Make predictions
- Ask questions and look for answers
- Visualize (make pictures in our mind or draw an image or diagram)
- Show agree/disagreements
- Identify problems and/or solutions
- Make connections to ourselves (our background, values, etc), other texts (articles, books, movies, etc), or the world (news events, politics, etc)
- Mark key points
- Summarize key points/ sections of the reading
- Make note of information that shocks, surprises, or challenges us and our beliefs
- Identify unfamiliar vocabulary or parts that are unclear

Some readers also like to

- underline or use symbols to point out key information
- write key words in the margin
- circle definitions and meanings
- write questions in the margins where answers can be found
- identify steps with numbers
- draw arrows to show relationships
- write short summaries in the margins

Practicing annotation

Now let's use active reading strategies and annotation with a short academic article.

Try this!

1. Use the active reading strategies to get an overview of this article.
2. Annotate as you read the article, “Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer – Not More dangerous – New Study Finds.”

Reading from an online magazine: Undocumented immigrants may actually make American communities safer – not more dangerous – new study finds

Robert M. Adelman, University at Buffalo and Lesley Reid, University of Alabama

The Research Brief is a short take about interesting academic work.

The big idea

Undocumented immigration does not increase the violent crime rate in U.S. metropolitan areas. In fact, it may reduce property crime rates. These are the key findings from our recently published article in the Journal of Crime and Justice, co-authored by Yulin Yang, James Bachmeier and Mike Maciag.

Research shows that the American communities where immigrants make their homes are more often improved by their presence than harmed by it. Immigrants bring social, cultural and economic activity to the places they live. That makes these places more vital and safer, not more dangerous.

Why it matters

People from all social groups and backgrounds commit crimes. But undocumented immigrants, and immigrants more generally, are often baselessly blamed for increasing crime rates – including, repeatedly, by President Donald Trump. In the second and final presidential debate, Trump again claimed undocumented immigrants are rapists and murderers.

This notion has existed and been studied since the early 20th century, including in a 2005 analysis we conducted with a number of colleagues that concluded immigration did not increase crime rates in U.S. metropolitan areas.

But this research is often dismissed because most empirical studies cannot separate undocumented immigrants from the total immigrant population. That level of analysis is necessary to draw conclusions about the relationship between undocumented immigration and crime.

For example, we found in a 2017 study with colleagues that from 1970 to 2010 metropolitan areas with greater concentrations of immigrants, legal and undocumented combined, have less property crime than areas with fewer immigrants, on average. Critics suggested that our findings would not hold if we looked at only the subset of undocumented individuals.

So we decided to find out if they were right. Our new study is the result of that effort, and it confirms our original findings: Undocumented immigration, on average, has no effect on violent crime across U.S. metropolitan areas.

In statistical models that did identify a significant relationship between undocumented immigration and crime, we found undocumented immigration reduces property crimes, such as burglary.

How we do our work

Using two different estimates of the undocumented immigrant populations for 154 metropolitan areas in our most recent study – one from the Pew Research Center and one from the Migration Population Institute – we examined the effect of undocumented immigration on homicide, aggravated assault, robbery, burglary and larceny crime rates.

Crime rate data came from the FBI's Uniform Crime Report program. Other data were from the U.S. Census Bureau.

Using a statistical method called regression analysis to examine the data, we found that as the size of the undocumented population increases, the property crime rate decreases, on average. And the size of the undocumented population in a metropolitan area tends to have no impact on the violent crime rate.

These findings build on the conclusions of a large 2018 study in which researchers Graham Ousey and Charis Kubrin examined 51 studies on immigration and crime published from 1994 to 2014.

What still isn't known

Our analyses looked at broad metropolitan patterns, not the relationship of undocumented immigration and crime rates in distinct, specific places such as New York City and Los Angeles. Nor does our study address the reasons that immigration reduces crime, although there is plenty of other scholarship on that issue. (Picture: The Conversation)

Robert M. Adelman, Associate Professor and Department Chair of Sociology, *University at Buffalo* and Lesley Reid, Professor of Criminology and Criminal Justice and Interim Dean of the School of Social Work, *University of Alabama*

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Reflect on your annotations

Discuss your annotations with a partner or in small groups. What observations can you make? What worked well? What was confusing? In what way did your annotations reinforce your learning? What kinds of annotations did you apply the most from the list below? Which types of annotations did you not try? Why do you think that is? What do you plan to do differently when you annotate again?

- Make predictions
- Ask questions and look for answers
- Visualize (make pictures in your mind or draw an image or diagram)
- Show agreements or disagreements
- Identify problems and/or solutions
- Make connections to yourself (your background, values, etc), other texts (articles, books, movies, etc), or the world (news events, politics, etc)
- Mark key points
- Summarize key points or sections of the reading
- Make note of information that shocks, surprises, or challenges you and your beliefs
- Identify parts that are unclear

Works Cited

Adelman, Robert M. and Lesley Reid. "Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer – Not More Dangerous – New Study Finds." *The Conversation,* 27 Oct. 2020

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Links on the original page

- "A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is a Win for All": https://www.virginiamercury.com/2020/03/27/a-win-for-undocumented-immigrants-is-a-win-for-all/
- original article: https://theconversation.com/undocumented-immigrants-may-actually-make-american-communities-safer-not-more-dangerous-new-study-finds-146829

1.5.1: 1.5.1 Accessible Version of Annotation Example on 1.5

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Accessible version of the annotation example on 1.5

Bold indicates parts the reader has marked to comment on; [words in brackets] shows the notes the reader has made.

A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is **a Win for All** [Will look for exactly how the new law helps everyone and mark with *]

Guest Column by Tram Nguyen, *Virginia Mercury*, March 27, 2020

Every person in Virginia deserves to live in their community free from fear.

The exclusion of undocumented Virginians from being able to drive has been a crippling barrier to that principle. **But the state legislature has now passed a bill that will allow driving for many immigrant residents** [the law changed] through **driver privilege cards** [How are these different from a driver's license?] this session. At New Virginia Majority we have organized and advocated for this basic right, and now **previously undocumented** [What does "previously undocumented" mean? Does the driver's license count as a document?] families and communities will legally be able to drive in the state of Virginia.

Having the right to drive can be **a matter of life and death** [importance] under everyday circumstances: a sick child that needs immediate medical attention, or a woman getting ready to bring a new life into the world. Most of us take this access for granted. This is a crucial advancement – for those that have waited patiently just to be able to drive themselves to work, take their children to doctor's appointments, or attend local events, this a chance to become fully active members of their community.

Ovidia Castillo Rosa [important person in the article], a member of New Virginia Majority's Loudoun County chapter described it best:" Not having a driver's license is like not having feet. **Being able to drive would be like having wings.** [great simile] When I have a driver's license, there are so many things that I'll have the freedom to do, including starting my own business."

Cecilia Cruz [important person in the article], a member of the New Virginia Majority, has been involved in the fight for the right to drive, and has called her representatives, and encouraged her friends and neighbors to march in support. **"The streets will be more safe and more money will stay in the state,"** [* how the new law helps everyone], she said. "Families will be able to leave their children and go to work in safety, without fear."

Providing this

credential

will give thousands of Virginians the ability to legally drive and is a huge victory. **But** [Maybe this signals a concession?] , **we recognize driver privilege cards are not the same as driver's licenses**, [Yes, it is a concession.] and there is much more to be done. Our communities, in an era of open and growing institutional racism and xenophobia, understand that having a driver's privilege card has the potential to make them vulnerable, as **it will make them immediately identifiable as an undocumented person** [Privilege cards are not enough. I wonder how many eligible people will not get one for fear of being identifiable.] and creates a segment of immigrant drivers.

Our organizers, advocates, and chapter members will continue to fight for a society that treats people equally and with dignity no matter what their status, language, zip code, gender, race, or ethnicity is, and we will work to strengthen **privacy** [What does privacy mean in this context? Why did Nguyen emphasize this here?] protections for all Virginians, regardless of immigration status.

When the presidential election comes to a close in the fall, we pledge to stand by immigrant communities and keep them informed of both the opportunities and threats presented by this law, regardless of who holds the office.

We believe in a Virginia that is welcoming and provides an opportunity for all its residents to succeed and live happy and healthy lives. The outcome of this legislative session was a step in the right direction and toward a more inclusive Virginia. **But** [Looks like turning back from this other concession] until all of our communities are granted the full protections and access to driver's licenses, **the fight continues**. [Still fighting]